2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Maria Monje

Grade / Grado 8

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Antonio Monje

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Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- (●) Father / Padre
- ( ) Grandfather / Abuelo
- ( ) Stepdad / Padrasto
- ( ) Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

When people hear the word father/dad, they might think it only means a man who has children. Except, fatherhood is much deeper than that. Being a father is not only just about giving a child food, clothes, and a place to live. It is about being present, teaching important lessons, and showing love every single day. A father plays a huge role in helping a child grow into a responsible and confident adult.

One important part of fatherhood is being a role model. Children learn by watching what adults do. If a father treats others with respect, works hard, and stays honest, his child will likely copy those behaviors. For example, if a father admits when he makes a mistake and apologizes, his child learns that nobody is perfect and that taking responsibility is important. These everyday moments may seem small, but they shape a child ' s character over time.

Another big part of fatherhood is support. Growing up can be confusing and stressful. Kids deal with school pressure, friendships, and sometimes personal struggles. A father who listens without judging and gives helpful advice can make a big difference. Even something simple, like asking how their day was or helping with homework, shows care. When fathers attend school events, sports games, or performances, it makes children feel proud and valued. Support builds confidence and helps kids believe they can reach their goals.

Fatherhood also means setting boundaries. While it is important to be kind and loving, it is also important to teach discipline. Rules help children understand right from wrong and keep them safe. A good father explains why rules matter instead of just giving punishments. This helps children understand the reasons behind decisions and learn self-control.

Most importantly, fatherhood is about love. Love can be shown in many ways. Some fathers say " I love you " often, while others show love by working hard to provide for their family. Love can be seen in small actions like cooking dinner, fixing something that is broken, or giving advice when it is needed. When children feel loved, they feel safe and secure. That feeling stays with them as they grow up.

In conclusion, fatherhood is more than just a title. It is a daily responsibility that includes teaching, guiding, supporting, and loving a child. A father helps shape who a child becomes in the future. Even though no father is perfect, the effort and care they give can leave a lasting impact. Fatherhood is one of the most important roles in a family and in a child ' s life.

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.